

Hardselling TERROR

The political exploitation of terror reaches a new high with BJP leaders coming to the defence of the accused

| By Bhavna Vij-Aurora |

Terror sells. In the back alleys of Indian politics, victimhood has direct access to the votebank. The only jarring irony is that, invariably, the bestselling victim is not the target of terrorism but the alleged—or even convicted—terrorist himself. The latest dateline that vindicates this truism is Malegaon, though this time around, terror has got a new religious identity: 'Hindu'. And it is proving to be politically explosive.

As Malegaon is all set to influence the political agenda—and may even shape a few slogans—in the run-up to the Lok Sabha elections, only the politically naïve would be surprised at the sight of BJP's prime ministerial candidate coming to the defence of the 'targeted' Hindu. He got an issue that is more 'explosive' than the nuclear deal—and a cause that appeals to the Hindutva core. If there was a surprise, it was about why he took so long to react. For, L.K. Advani, who had kept a safe distance from the issue in the be-

ginning—maintaining let-the-law-take-its-course—finally jumped into the fray by taking up cudgels for Sadhvi Pragya Singh. He said he was shocked and outraged by the "barbaric treatment" being meted out to a "spiritual person" by the Maharashtra Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS), investigating the Malegaon blast. He said that the ATS was acting in a "politically-motivated and unprofessional manner" and demanded that the investigating team be changed, and a judicial probe be ordered into the Sadhvi's charges and the unsubstantiated allegations made against a serving army officer. He was reacting to the affidavit filed by the Sadhvi in a Nashik court, alleging illegal detention and torture.

The real reason for Advani's tough tenor and joining in the Sangh Parivar chorus is Elections 2009. "The party has got ground reports from the cadres that the accused in the case have immense sympathy from the Hindus. The RSS has been saying that



instead of appearing apologetic, the party should use it to its advantage. After all, Narendra Modi came back as chief minister of Gujarat with a thumping victory on his tough Hindutva stand," said a BJP official. It was party President Rajnath Singh who first came out in support of the Sadhvi. Several others, including Advani, were initially in favour of distancing themselves from the case, maintaining that if there was evidence against them, they should be punished. Waiting and watching for almost three weeks, Advani decided to go along with the flow, and the premise, that there was sympathy for the so-called "saffron bombers". During this period, there were extensive discussions with the RSS. Advani also used this time to get reports about the way the ATS was conducting investigations. The fact that the ATS tied itself in knots over several allegations, including backtracking on the charge that 60 kg RDX was pilfered by Lt-Colonel Shrikant Prasad Purohit for the Samjhauta Express blasts, helped Advani make up his mind, and go

“ I cannot believe that such barbaric treatment has been meted out to a spiritual person. I demand a judicial inquiry. ”

L.K. ADVANI, BJP leader, on Sadhvi Pragya Singh (right)

